



Logged In, Blamed Anyway

A Badge-Tap Log Against a Break-Room Fish Tank’s Paper Feeding Roster

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Motivation

Office fish tanks increasingly pair an automatic feeder with a taped-up paper roster, and a missed feed reliably reopens who forgot. Little is known about whether a machine’s own timestamp actually closes that argument, or simply gives it a second exhibit.

Aims

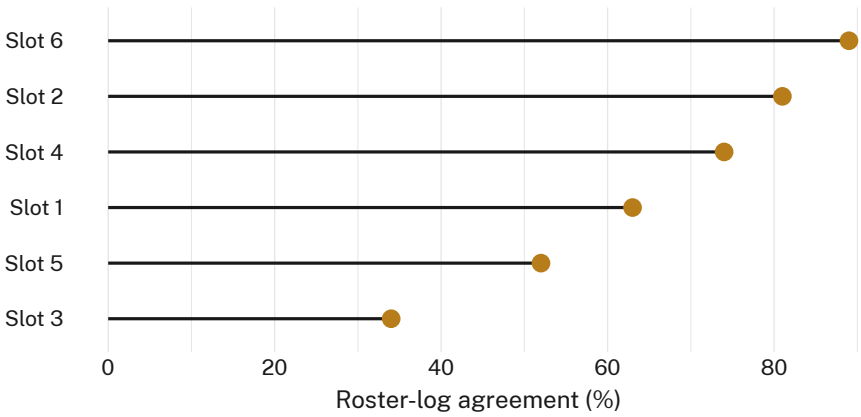
- Test whether a logged feed event matches that week’s rostered name
- Track what happens to the roster once a mismatch becomes visible
- Check whether logging changes how often a feed is missed at all

Study design

- 3 shared offices · 54 rostered weeks · 18 weeks each · one badge-tap logger per tank
- “Feeder Ledger” app time-stamps each tap against the badge holder; the paper roster left untouched
- Mismatch follow-up at the next roster refresh; no coaching, reminder, or roster redesign introduced

Results

Results suggest the logged presser matched the rostered name in 61% of weeks overall (n = 54); the missed-feed rate held flat before and after the logger’s install (9% vs 8% of weeks). Agreement peaked on the slot immediately after a public holiday and troughed on the slot spanning a fortnightly all-hands, when the rostered feeder was most often away from their desk.



Roster-log agreement by weekly rotation slot ranged from 34% to 89% across six recurring slots (n = 54 rostered weeks, three offices, 18 weeks each, October 2025 – February 2026).

Interpretation & Takeaways

Results suggest a verified timestamp settles nothing on its own. Of 21 mismatched weeks, the roster was corrected to match the log in 8 and left standing in 13 — the paper square, not the sensor, still carried the final word more often than not. Corrections clustered in the fortnight after a mismatch was raised at a team meeting, then tapered off once the meeting’s attention moved on. The logger has not shortened a single feeding gap; it has only given the office a second record to argue from, and in two of the three offices the printed log sheet has itself begun to collect handwritten annotations, restoring exactly the ambiguity it was installed to remove. Next: a logger that overwrites the roster square directly, removing the option to leave the two in disagreement, and a follow-up on whether a forced overwrite simply moves the argument to whoever holds the marker.

References

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Instrumentation costs met from a School of Emergent Priorities seed allocation.

Badge-tap identifiers de-identified to office and slot only; no name or photo retained.

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